TOP 5 MOST IMPROVED COLLEGES ARTS

RANK	COLLEGE	CITY	RANK 2026	RANK 2022
1	MOUNT CARMEL COLLEGE (AUTONOMOUS)	Bengaluru	13	24
2	RAMNARAIN RUIA AUTONOMOUS COLLEGE	Mumbai	22	40
3	KIRORI MAL COLLEGE	New Delhi	4	7
4	ATMA RAM SANATAN DHARMA COLLEGE	New Delhi	6	10
5	SRI VENKATESWARA COLLEGE	New Delhi	9	14

An integral part of quintessential Bengaluru, Mount Carmel College (Autonomous) is located in the heart of the city, a stone's throw from the iconic Tudor-style Bengaluru Palace. Three years ago, on its platinum jubilee, the all-women's institution—whose alumnae include celebrated business leaders, bureaucrats, policymakers and actors—transitioned into a co-educational institution, a move aimed at serving the youth at large.

GURUSPEAK

"Since gaining autonomy in 2005, we have grown from 29 to over 80 programmes, while focusing on holistic development so students graduate well-rounded and ready to take on the world"

PROF. LEKHA GEORGE
Principal,
Mount Carmel College

"We are 78 years young," says Professor Lekha George, principal. "It was a humble beginning, with just 50 students; today, we have 10,400 students on campus. So, this is a huge milestone." In this year's Best Colleges Survey, the institution has risen to 13th place from 24th in 2022, making it the most improved college in its category.

The School of Humanities and Social Sciences offers various single-discipline and triple-discipline undergraduate courses. A distinct feature of the past year has been that every activity in the humanities stream—across major conferences, student projects and publications—was themed around two Sustainable Development Goals: Responsible Consumption and Production, and Health and Well-being.

"That is a huge impact factor for students because normally you see SDGs on a hoarding, but you don't really understand the logic behind them or why we are talking about them in the Indian context," says Dr Suma Singh, registrar-academics. "The idea is to translate them into the real world so that students are aware of what is happening and what needs to be done."

This approach has its advantages, she adds, because students "are able to think out of the box and come up with solutions to a lot of challenges that we are facing as a nation".

For the past three years in a row, students from the humanities stream have bagged some of the highest pay packages on campus during placements, a pointer both to the importance of all-round development and the increasing relevance of humanities subjects. "I think the future will be digital humanities," says Singh. The term refers to the application of digital tools to humanities subjects such as History, allowing for new ways of data visualisation and understanding. Dr Hamsa N., dean of humanities and social sciences, explains that Psychology, for instance, is another field where technology is being adopted, especially with the advent of digital therapies in treating anxiety and depression.

Gaining additional skills, Singh points out, is a key factor. The institute has 68 associations. "The campus gives you an opportunity to grow. We encourage students to be part of these associations, and that is where real learning happens—when they are curating and executing programmes," says Singh. "Mount Carmel's strengths lie in its faculty, diverse student body and numerous academic and non-academic associations, ensuring something meaningful for everyone here," says Jyeshta Sudhir Bangalore, third year student of BA Psychology, Journalism and English Literature. "My course's USP is its interconnected interdisciplinary subjects."

The college became autonomous in 2005. "At that time, we had just about 29 programmes. Today, we have over 80 programmes across UG, PG and PhD. We not only concentrate on academics but also make sure there is holistic overall development of our students," says Prof. Lekha. Having applied for university status, the college is now poised for a major transformation. ■

***The college that has shown the highest improvement in rankings between 2022 and 2026**